ludogic

10 gamification mechanics for your training

How to turn the course you already have into something people actually want to finish. No new course needed.

LEVEL 1 · START HERE

FREE GUIDE

01 Progress bar

02 Levels

03 Points & XP

04 Instant feedback

05 Lives

06 Countdown

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08 Streaks

09 Boss fight

10 Team score

Same content.
Different game.

Most corporate training fails for the same reason: people only see an obligation. Slides, a "Next" button and a quiz at the end that tells them nothing. Games solve exactly that problem, and you can borrow their mechanics without rebuilding your course.

1

Pick one module people struggle to finish. Don't gamify everything at once.

2

Add 2 or 3 mechanics from this guide. Each card tells you how, step by step.

3

Measure completion, time spent and quiz scores before and after.

01 **Progress bar with a head start**

02 **Short levels with unlocks**

03 **Points, XP and a speed bonus**

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10 **Team score**

Progress bar with a head start

01

A visible bar that shows how far people are. The trick: nobody starts at 0 %. Counting the intro already done makes the goal feel reachable.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Show "% complete" on every screen, not "Slide 12 of 40".
2. Count the welcome/intro as done, so people start at 10-15 %.
3. Add small milestones (25 %, 50 %, 75 %).

EXAMPLE

Onboarding course: the bar starts at 15 % ("You've completed your profile") and fills after each 5-minute block.

WATCH OUT

A bar that barely moves is worse than no bar. If a block takes 30 minutes, split it.

Short levels with unlocks

02

Games never show you the whole mountain. They show you level 1. Cut the course into short levels, each with a clear win, and unlock the next one when the current one is done.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Split modules into 5-10 minute levels.
2. Give each level one clear goal ("Spot a phishing email").
3. Show the map: done, current, locked.

EXAMPLE

A 60-minute compliance course becomes 8 levels on a map. Level 8 is the final challenge (see 09).

WATCH OUT

Locking content people need for their job is frustrating. Lock the *challenges*, keep reference material open.

XP Points, XP and a speed bonus

03

Points turn every answer into a small win. A speed bonus (more points for answering faster) adds focus without punishing anyone.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Give points for every correct answer and completed level.
2. Add a bonus for fast answers (e.g. 500 base + up to 500 for speed).
3. Show the score growing in real time.

EXAMPLE

Security quiz: "+840 points, speed bonus!" right after each answer, with the total always visible in the corner.

WATCH OUT

Points must mean something: tie them to a level, a badge or a team score, or they become noise.

Instant feedback

04

The most important mechanic of all. People learn at the moment they get something wrong, not three days later in an email with their score.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. After every answer, show right/wrong immediately.
2. When wrong, show *why* in one sentence, and the right answer.
3. Let them try again.

EXAMPLE

"Oops! It's phishing: report it, never click." Then the correct option lights up green.

WATCH OUT

"Incorrect" alone teaches nothing. The explanation is the lesson.

Lives: safe failure

05

Three hearts. A mistake costs one, but never ends the game. Mistakes matter a little, so people pay attention, but they never feel punished.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Give 3 lives per level.
2. A wrong answer costs a life and shows the explanation.
3. Losing all lives restarts the level, not the course.

EXAMPLE

Customer-service scenarios: each bad reply to the "angry customer" costs a heart. Three hearts lost: replay that conversation.

WATCH OUT

Never link lives to HR records or evaluations. The point is safe practice.

Countdown timer

06

A visible countdown (a bomb, a clock, a shrinking bar) creates focus. Combined with the speed bonus, it turns a quiz into a game.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Add a timer to quiz questions (15-30 seconds).
2. Use it for points, not for failing: time out = fewer points.
3. Make it visual and animated.

EXAMPLE

A bomb in the corner whose fuse burns down. Answer before it reaches zero for the full bonus.

WATCH OUT

Don't use timers for long reading or complex calculations, and offer extra time for accessibility needs.

Choices instead of slides

07

Don't read people the policy. Put them in the situation and let them decide. A branching scenario teaches the rule by making them use it.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Take one rule from your slides.
2. Turn it into a real situation with 2-4 options.
3. Each option shows its consequence.

EXAMPLE

Instead of "Policy 4.2: never share passwords", a colleague on screen asks: "Can I borrow your password?" → Sure / No way.

WATCH OUT

Wrong options must be believable. If the right answer is obvious, it's a slide again.

Streaks

08

A counter of consecutive days (or answers) in a row. Nobody wants to break their streak, which makes it great for short daily practice.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Offer a 2-3 minute daily micro-lesson or question.
2. Show the streak counter with a flame.
3. Allow a "freeze" day so one miss doesn't erase everything.

EXAMPLE

"Security minute": one question a day for a month. Day 5 in a row unlocks a bonus question.

WATCH OUT

Streaks work for habits, not for long courses. Keep the daily task tiny.

The final exam as a boss fight

09

Same questions, new frame. The exam becomes a "boss" with a health bar: every right answer is a hit, every miss the boss hits back.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Give the final test a character and a health bar.
2. Each correct answer removes health; mistakes cost a life.
3. Celebrate the win: "Boss defeated!"

EXAMPLE

"BOSS: FINAL EXAM" with 10 questions. Defeat it to unlock the certificate.

WATCH OUT

If the exam is mandatory for compliance, keep the official result separate from the game layer.

Team score

10

Individual leaderboards discourage the people at the bottom. A team score turns competition into collaboration: everyone's progress adds to the group.

ADD IT TO YOUR TRAINING

1. Group people into teams (departments, offices, cohorts).
2. Every completed level adds points to the team.
3. Show the team ranking, not individual names.

EXAMPLE

"Madrid office vs Barcelona office": the team with the highest completion this month wins a breakfast.

WATCH OUT

Never publish individual rankings of low performers. Celebrate progress, not position.

Start this week with just 3.

You don't need all ten. This combination works on almost any existing quiz and takes hours, not months.

MECHANIC 06

A timer

Answer faster, score more. Instant focus.

MECHANIC 05

Lives

Mistakes cost something, but never end the game.

MECHANIC 04

Instant feedback

Get one wrong and see why right away.

Checklist for your next course redesign

- [ ] Nobody starts at 0 % (progress bar with a head start)
- [ ] No module longer than 10 minutes without a win
- [ ] Every rule from the slides is practised as a choice
- [ ] Every answer gets feedback with the "why"
- [ ] Mistakes are safe: lives, retries, no records
- [ ] The final test feels like a challenge, not a punishment
- [ ] You measure completion and scores before and after

Want this in your training?
We design gamified training, onboarding and campaigns for teams.

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Background reading: Sailer, M. & Homner, L. (2020). The Gamification of Learning: a Meta-analysis. Educational Psychology Review 32, 77-112. Examples in this guide are illustrative.